RALA STORY





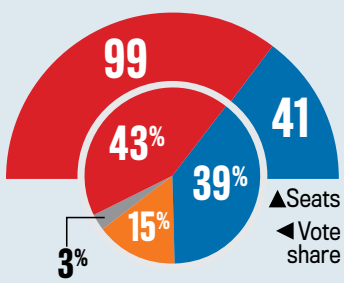
THRUST & PARRY CM Pinarayi with CPI(M) candidate and sitting Alappuzha MP A.M Ariff; Congress MP and party candidate in Wayanad Rahul Gandhi with sister Priyanka Vadra at a roadshow

AASISH MANOLI

While seat and vote share patterns inverted for LDF and UDF in the LS and assembly polls, the NDA's vote share stayed steady

ASSEMBLY 2021

(Total seats: 140)



UDF LDF NDA Others

Vote share figures have been rounded off

space, the lotus blooms on every lamp-post and city wall, media debates run on BJP-ordained terms—signs of its vast resources, and presence at the political arrival lounge, are everywhere. The other is older. Though yoked together with I.N.D.I.A. nationally, the Left and Congress here come off a bitter, blood-soaked 75 years of rivalry. So bitter that Kerala's veto has defined key national moments of abdication for the CPI(M): India would have had Jyoti Basu as PM in 1997, and the UPA ties would have endured in 2008, if not for the "nyet" ringing out from its hard-boiled tropical commissars. That animus is not just memory: the older Left party, the CPI, has fielded Annie Raja, social activist and wife of general secretary D. Raja, against Rahul. Both contestants are civil by nature, but by no means is it a friendly fight.

So the outer shape of the contest is triangular. In a nutshell, the Congress hopes Malayalis revert to their 2019 'national' pattern of voting for the GOP. The Left is understandably not amenable to that thought: for them, Kerala is the last red sea from which to churn out some semblance of a resur-